

Task Batching

A Deep Focus Guide

Why grouping similar work reduces cognitive switching cost, and a practical protocol for batching your own week.

Evidence-based approach: Rubinstein, Meyer & Evans (2001), *Journal of Experimental Psychology*; Leroy (2009), *Organizational Behavior and Human Decision Processes* (attention residue).

Why It Works

Every time you switch from one type of task to a different type, your brain pays a 'switch cost' — a measurable delay and error-rate increase documented by Rubinstein, Meyer, and Evans in 2001. Sophie Leroy's later research on 'attention residue' found that part of your attention stays stuck on the previous task even after you've moved on, degrading performance on the new one. Batching similar tasks together — all emails, all calls, all creative writing — minimizes the number of switches your brain has to absorb.

Batching Categories At A Glance

Category	Example Tasks	Best Time
Deep work	Writing, coding, analysis	First 2-3 hrs of the day
Shallow admin	Email, Slack, scheduling	Fixed windows, 2-3x/day
Communication	Calls, meetings	Clustered mid-day
Creative/low-stakes	Brainstorming, reading	Afternoon energy dip

A Simple Weekly Protocol

1. List every recurring task type from the past two weeks — don't filter yet.
2. Group tasks into 4-6 categories by the mental mode they require, not by project.
3. Assign each category a fixed daily or weekly window, protecting your highest-energy hours for deep work.
4. Batch-process shallow admin (email, messages) in 2-3 scheduled windows instead of continuously.
5. Review weekly — merge categories that rarely fill their window, split ones that overflow.

Sources

Rubinstein, J.S., Meyer, D.E., & Evans, J.E. (2001). Executive Control of Cognitive Processes in Task Switching. *Journal of Experimental Psychology: Human Perception and Performance*.

Leroy, S. (2009). Why is it so hard to do my work? The challenge of attention residue when switching between work tasks. *Organizational Behavior and Human Decision Processes*.